

WATER

According to an ancient Chinese proverb, water is the “mother of tea.” Because it makes up 99 percent of a cup of tea, there is some truth to this. The quality of water you infuse with has a major impact on the flavor of your tea. To get the best out of your tea leaves, use clean and odorless water that has been heated to the right temperature.

Rainfall, pollution, and the local aquifer (porous underground rock from which groundwater is extracted) all affect your local water source, whether rural or urban. These factors influence the mineral and odor content of the water and its pH—the measurement, from 0–14, of acidity (at the low end) or alkalinity (at the high end) in liquids.

Generally, water has a neutral pH of 7, but sometimes tap water can be a little too alkaline or acidic for tea. Tap water also contains dissolved gases, which might have odors, or could be highly mineralized, which can overpower the delicate flavors in the infusion.

If you don’t have a filter attached to your water system that dispenses pure water for tea, you can try using these alternatives:

Bottled spring water Not to be confused with mineral water, which is unsuitable due to the minerals added; look for spring water with 50–100ppm dissolved mineral salt content. Higher amounts will give a heavy mineral flavor to the tea.

Filtered tap water Portable water filter jugs work well to filter out unwanted odors and minerals from tap water. Change the filter as recommended.

Distilled water mixed with tap water Distilled water is flat and unappealing, but adding it to tap water that has a high mineral content will make it suitable for tea. Experiment with various ratios depending on the quality of your tap water.

WATER TEMPERATURES

Boiling point varies according to elevation. If you live in an area over 4,265ft (1,300m) above sea level, your water will not have reached 210°F (100°C) when your kettle turns off. To compensate for this, add an extra half teaspoon of tea leaves per person and leave the infusion for a few extra minutes.

THE RIGHT HEAT

If the water for the infusion is too hot, the tea will be bitter and lose its aroma; if too cold, the tea will not infuse properly.

